

AP PHOTO: RIAZ KHAN



UP IN ARMS: Militants stand guard outside a building in Swat where paramilitary troops have been held hostage

figures more than ever. There is increasing disquiet even within the armed forces over the likely repercussions of the current state of events. "This is going to sink the army," says a retired colonel on the condition of anonymity. "People were already upset with us, they are now going to openly turn against us." A day after the imposition of Musharraf's decree, rumours spread like wildfire that the corps' commanders had staged a coup and put Musharraf under house arrest. Musharraf dismissed it as "a joke of the highest order". The stock market reacted to the rumours of instability by crashing almost five per cent, wiping out almost Rs 19,000 crore of capitalisation. The wheels of the regime were coming off.

One of Musharraf's stated reasons for the imposition of Emergency was the need for an all-out fight against rising militancy, an objective that po-

larises Pakistani society. Many see this as a US agenda, with the Pakistan Army being used to attack its own people. The army is already bogged down with and is suffering heavy casualties in the tribal areas of Waziristan bordering Afghanistan, where more than 1,000 soldiers have died so far. Now the battle has spread to areas of the Frontier Province, in particular the picturesque Swat valley, where local Taliban-like militants, demanding Islamic law, have taken control of up to three districts and openly begun attacking paramilitary forces.

There have recently been well-targeted deadly attacks on Inter-Services Intelligence (ISI) personnel in Rawalpindi, army commandos in their training camp at Tarbela and air force personnel in Sargodha, all of which point to a sophisticated intelligence input indica-

tive of the involvement of Al Qaeda.

Musharraf may feel he needs his uniform to lead the fight against such militancy. The problem, however, is that almost no one believes that this can be rooted out through military means alone. "Military solutions alone, without any democratic alternatives for the people, are likely to exacerbate the situation," says Talat Aslam, editor of *The News* in Karachi. Questions have also been raised about the regime's sincerity in battling extremism. Musharraf blamed the judiciary for setting free hardcore terrorists from the Lal Mosque as part of his chargesheet against the judges and claimed those set free were probably involved in extremist activities. However, the two judges primarily responsible for letting go the apprehended suspects, were among the first to take oath under the new Constitutional Order.

In the face of mounting dismay over his actions, Musharraf's only ray of hope is absolute lack of mobilisation by political parties. While some political leaders have taken refuge in the plea that they have been placed under



MILITANTS HAVE SPREAD ALL OVER PAKISTAN. THEY STRIKE AT MILITARY TARGETS AND THE MORALE OF THE FORCES HAS BEGUN TO SAP.